inspire their online actions, and the social norms they develop around how to behave and what counts as skill and competence. Social shaping and domestication approaches would do as this chapter has, looking at both the technological factors and the social ones that combine unpredictably to create practices and outcomes that have not yet cohered into clear consequences. What does seem clear at this point is that new media do not offer inauthentic simulations that detract from or substitute for real engagement. As we will continue to see in the remaining chapters, what happens through mediation is interwoven, not juxtaposed, with everything else.

5

New relationships, new selves?

Tom was a sweet and thoughtful guy who took my class about online interaction in the mid 1990s. In one paper, he explored what would happen if he represented himself in different ways through his America Online profile. He created one profile as a stereotypically sexy young woman who described herself as liking fast cars she didn't know much about and liking men who did. Within hours of logging in as "Busty," he had received dozens of personal messages inviting him backstage for some quick cybersex. It was his first experience of the receiving end of sexism and, though it wasn't hard for some of us to see it coming, it left him aghast. Some months later, he decided he was ready to find committed romance. His friend advised him that the best strategy was to log onto America Online and search the profiles for women in the city who were online and shared his interests, then send them a private message. He took the advice, combined it with the lesson he had learned as Busty ("treat women as people"), and quickly fell into an exchange of messages with a woman who lived nearby but whom he'd never met. The chat progressed so well that, within a couple of hours, she gave him her phone number and told him to call. He called immediately and they spoke on the phone for an hour before she suggested that they meet for dinner that night. She brought friends, just in case he turned out to be a psychokiller. He wasn't, their chemistry was undeniable, and by day's end they were en route to their eventual marriage. Though they had met in person the same day they met online, when her family attended his graduation ceremony, one commented "wow, you really were a graduate student!" Because they had met online, some in her family still doubted his honesty.

Tom's story encapsulates the utopian potential the internet

holds for our relationships – we can meet new people and form rewarding new relationships – as well as the common concerns that the people we meet online cannot be trusted and may even be dangerous. Busty could be Tom. Tom could be a fraud or even a killer. When the telegraph took off, operators working in telegraph offices soon found that the time between customers was well spent using the technology to chat with telegraph operators in other offices in the network. As Standage (1998) recounts, this led to the formation of new relationships, many of which were regarded with suspicion by the relational partners' families and peers. In chapter 2, we saw that, throughout the history of electronic communication, some have celebrated the ability to form new relationships across time and space, but others have seen it as enabling communication between people who should not be forming relationships and as offering pale substitutes for authentic connection. The internet has been heralded for its potential to bridge divides and create meaningful new connections, but more often accused of leading people to lie about themselves, making victims of women and children, or taking people away from the relationships they should be having with their families and communities.

Initially, most of the focus in both the popular imagination and internet scholarship was on the development of new relationships between strangers who met through the internet. In this chapter and the next we will look at the processes of forming new relationships through the internet. This chapter focuses on first meeting new people online. After discussing how and why people form new relationships through the internet, I turn to the questions of identity, asking what forces shape people's online self-presentations and whether they are more likely to be honest or deceptive. Finally, the chapter returns to the question of authenticity, asking whether the identities and new connections people construct online are as real as those built offline.

New relationships online

The internet has brought to all of its users the possibility of forming relationships that transcend space. As shared location has lost its status as a prerequisite for first meeting, the range of potential relational partners has been expanded to a broader pool than at any previous point in history. Most often, relationships emerge naturally out of the online communities and networks we discussed in the previous chapter. In the soap opera discussion forum I studied, rec.arts.tv.soaps (r.a.t.s.), many friendships developed in the course of talking about soap operas and the tangents that discussion prompted. Participants often described the group as "a bunch of close friends" (Baym, 2000). This was typical for newsgroups. In the early 1990s, Parks and Floyd (1996) sampled 24 Usenet newsgroups and then emailed a survey to a sampling of people who had posted to each group. They found that 60.7 percent of respondents had established a personal relationship of some sort through the group, regardless of what kind of group it was. In a follow-up survey of MOO participants, Parks and Roberts (1998) found that so many respondents had formed personal relationships through MOOs that there weren't enough people left over without such relationships to use for comparison.

Although people mainly use social network sites (SNSs) to maintain existing relationships (as we'll cover in the next chapter), they are sites of new relationship formation as well. Haythornthwaite (2002) coined the term "latent tie" to refer to potential relationships within a social circle that are structurally enabled but have not been activated. Friends of friends on Facebook are a good example of latent ties and a source of new relationships. By making friends' lists visible and, in some cases, offering automated recommendations of latent ties, the architecture of social network sites facilitates the conversion of latent ties to acquaintanceships (Ellison et al., 2007).

People may also explicitly seek new partners online, which accounts for the rise of dating sites such as eHarmony.com and Match.com, as well as start-ups like omegle.com, a chat platform that randomly pairs strangers for real-time interaction. Match making is not new to digital media. Newspapers have long hosted classified ads for those seeking romance and, in alternative publications, playmates. When media become "marriage market intermediaries" they blur interpersonal and mass communication

(Adelman & Ahuvia, 1991). Ideologies of romanticism, in which true love arises out of unpredictable moments of serendipitous fate, are pitted against ideologies of social exchange in which finding love through media seems more of a business transaction than destiny and people are reduced to dehumanizing lists of attributes (Adelman & Ahuvia, 1991).

There are many reasons people might form new relationships online even when they don't go looking for them, including the communication imperative, assumed similarity, and reduced social risk. Regardless of medium, people are intrinsically motivated to reduce our uncertainty about others and find affinities with them (Walther, 1992). Walther (1992) proposed the Social Information Processing (SIP) model to explain relational development online. In his 1992 piece and in Walther et al. (1994: 465), he argued that, because people need to reduce uncertainty, in online contexts they "adapt their linguistic and textual behaviors to the solicitation and presentation of socially revealing, relational behavior." The longer the interaction lasts or the more expectation the participants have of continued interaction, the more true this is (Walther, 1994).

When people are in a discussion forum based on common interest, there is a presumption of similarity which can make potential partners seem more attractive. "When someone joins a newsgroup devoted to, for example, aging ferrets," write McKenna et al. (2002: 11), "he or she already knows that there is a shared base of interest with the others there." Similarity functions as a form of propinquity (Baker, 2008). Online, we bump into the people who share our interests rather than those who happen to be in the same physical location. This leads to connections that might not otherwise form. The internet also lowers the social risk of communicating. We saw this, for example, in last chapter's discussion of McKenna and Bargh's (1998) work on newsgroups for homosexuals and will return to it later in this chapter. Just as people spill their secrets to strangers seated beside them on airplanes, the anonymity of online interactions makes some people more willing to disclose and fosters new relationship formation.

Given these advantages of new media, one could imagine a world in which they are wholeheartedly embraced as a wonderful

opportunity. But shared location has been intrinsic to our understandings of how relationships start and their place in our personal networks for millennia. We are most likely to form relationships with those with whom we get the chance to interact, and, without communication technology, those are the people who are most likely to be in the same place at the same time. In substituting interest or other factors for place, mediated meeting challenges much of what we've taken for granted in forming relationships for most of human history.

Mediated meeting also challenges our conventional understandings of relationship building because we are used to assessing people and doing much of the work of getting closer through nonverbal signals. We often size people up and decide whether or not to talk to them based on how they look. At least in romantic relationships, people may be most motivated to pursue connections with those whose level of physical attractiveness matches their own, a phenomenon known as the "matching hypothesis" (Berscheid, Dion, Hatfield, & Walster, 1971). In online contexts, we may be unaware of what our communication partner looks like, or may not find out until well into the relationship. Even when there are photographs, they may be carefully selected to present one's best look rather than one's everyday appearance. Once a relationship has begun, nonverbal cues are important in its development. We smile, make eye contact, stand closer and touch to signal attraction and deepen our bonds (e.g. Knapp, 1983). How then can we form relationships in the absence of such nonverbal messages? And what are the consequences of doing so?

One answer, as we saw in the third chapter, is that even text-based new media afford many ways to express emotion. We use emoticons to signal friendliness, we use punctuation and capitalization to insert feeling, we use informal language and talk-like phonetic spellings to create an air of conversationality. Multimedia platforms let us share video and engage in real-time video chat. We use language to talk about our feelings. Socioemotional communication may be easier face to face, but it is common and successful in digital media as well. In one of his SIP studies, Walther (1994) conducted experiments with groups who had never met. They were

told either that this was a one-shot meeting or that they would be interacting again in the future. When people expected to interact again they were more likely to express immediacy and affection, similarity and depth, trust and composure.

Another reason for societal discomfort with online relationship formation is that these new relationships are often between categories of people who would not have as much of a chance to form relationships offline. People communicating in different locations, relying on textual and digital nonverbal cues, are more likely to form relationships that blur the social boundaries between groups and hence challenge social norms of appropriateness. This is another way in which new relationship formation online challenges conventional notions of what relationships are and should be. New media make it easier to have "pure relationships," in which the relationship is its own reward instead of serving a useful function in maintaining the social order (Clark, 1998; Giddens, 1993). Standage (1998) wrote of then-shocking interracial relationships that emerged through the telegraph, as well as of romances formed without parental consent and over parental objections. One couple was even married by telegraph in distant locations to avert the marriage the bride's father had planned for her. Though her father challenged the marriage's authenticity, given that the couple were not co-located during the ceremony, it was upheld by the courts.

Friendships between women and men are more common in online contexts. Offline, these relationships are generally seen as a threat to the social order (e.g. Rawlins, 1992). In English they are described with the term "just friends," betraying the cultural definition of such relationships as something less than would be expected of a man and a woman. Parks and Roberts (1998) surveyed users of seven MOOs by contacting them directly and asking them to describe a recent person with whom they had communicated recently on the site and to compare that relationship to an offline relationship. They found far more cross-sex friendships in MOOs than face to face. In a survey of users of the international music-oriented SNS Last.fm, I asked people to describe a random on-site friendship. Relationships on Last.fm were as likely to be cross-sex as same-sex, making the former more common on Last.fm than offline (Baym & Ledbetter, 2009). In a survey of nearly 1,000 Israeli teens, Mesch and Talmud (2006) also found more cross-sex relationships between online than offline friends.

Relationships that transcend age barriers may also be more common online (Mesch & Talmud, 2006), although we did not find this to be the case on Last.fm (Baym & Ledbetter, 2009). People in their forties and teenagers who share guild membership in online role-playing games may become friends; people who share musical taste may connect without even knowing one another's age in music-oriented sites and groups; television fans may bond over shows regardless of age. When cross-sex and cross-age friends interact online, they are less likely to face the pressures of others' (and, for some, their own) suspicions than they are if they socialize face to face. These relationships may thus be easier to create and maintain online than off.

Identity

Flexibility and multiplicity

Without doubt, the issues that shake people the most about forming relationships online center on identity. When people's bodies aren't visible, will people lie about who they are? Can they be known? Can they be trusted? Can the relationships they form be valid? Alternatively, might some be liberated? An *Off the Mark* cartoon by Mark Parisi (2009), titled "Life before the internet," echoed many of the concerns we saw in cartoons and advice columns in chapter 2. In the cartoon, an unattractive man sat before a desk with nothing on it. "I'm pretending to be handsome," said the thought bubble over his head, "Yup, athletic too . . . Now I'm pretending to be a woman."

Many scholars have noted that digital media, especially the internet, disrupt the notion held dear in many cultures that each body gets one self (e.g. Stone, 1995). Digital media seem to separate selves from bodies, leading to *disembodied identities* that exist only in actions and words. This disembodiment opens up new

possibilities for exploration and deception. People can certainly lie in person, but it is hard (though by no means impossible) to pretend to be the other sex or a different age. Many academic reports in the early 1990s focused on Multi-User Domains (MUDs) and MOOs in which much of the point was to play with identity. However, observational research showed that, even in those environments where people could self-present as anything from a monster to a six-pack of beer, most people did not take advantage of disembodiment to create fantastic or radically deceptive selves (Curtis, 1997).

The disembodied identities presented online can also be multiple. On Last.fm, for instance, I am Popgurl, a self-representation I took great pains to keep separate from Nancy Baym for some time before publicly claiming her. In the fan board discussing my favorite band, I used my cat's name, not because I didn't want the others in the group to know who I am, but because I didn't want that fangirl to show up when people search for this academic on Google. A search for Nancy Baym will turn up my academic persona on my university website, a more well-rounded if trite self-presentation on Twitter, and a more pop-culture-oriented self on my blog. All of these are genuine parts of me, but online they are segmented into separate spaces where they can become distinct identities. My son, well socialized by educators to believe it's dangerous to reveal his underage status or identifying information online, maintains several different identities with different names, ages, and locations in different sites on the internet.

Such multiplicity is enhanced on the internet, but it is nothing new. It was Shakespeare who wrote that "all the world's a stage," recognizing that all of our social encounters involve playing roles designed to suit the interactants and the context. Identity scholars such as Goffman (1959) have long argued that the self plays multiple roles in everyday life and cannot be understood adequately as a single unified entity. Rather than there being One True Self, variations of which are inherently false, contemporary scholars have come to see the self as flexible and multiple, taking different incarnations in different situations. Finkenauer, Engels, Meeus, and Oosterwegel (2002: 28), for instance, defined identity as

representing "the aspect of the self that is accessible and salient in a particular context and that interacts with the environment." Turkle (1996: 14) used the metaphor of windows. If you think of a computer screen, an internet user may have multiple windows open. In one, he is playing a warlock in a role-playing game; in another he is chatting with his best friend in another town; in a third, he is working on homework; in yet another, he's drafting an email to his parents; and in a fifth, he's in a chat room pretending to be a woman. "Windows have become a powerful metaphor for thinking about the self as a multiple, distributed system," Turkle writes; "The self is no longer simply playing different roles in different settings at different times. The life practice of windows is that of a decentered self that exists in many worlds, that plays many roles at the same time." Now the embodied self, as one of Turkle's interviewees put it, may be "just one more window."

Knowing bodies is often seen as key to knowing individuals, to determining whether their actions are valid, and to holding them accountable for what they do (Stone, 1995). When there's no body attached to behavior, the authenticity of behavior becomes less clear. It took a nineteenth-century court to determine that the marriage ceremony conducted via telegraph counted as real despite the lack of co-presence and the bride's father's objections (Standage, 1998). Consider the example of the "cyberaffairs" we saw cited repeatedly in the advice columns of the American 1990s as one of the internet's worst relational consequences. For the letter writers, there was no question such relationships were affronts to their marriages, but whether they constitute adultery is less clear. Divorce courts increasingly deliberate cases in which one partner has been accused of "adultery" for an "affair" carried on through the verbal description of sex acts with a partner online. Most of us may feel betrayed were this to happen in our relationships, but does a sex act count as a sex act without bodies? Can it be adultery if they never physically touched? The problem of what kinds of realities are warranted by online behaviors are by no means limited to sex. What about when an avatar "steals" a digital object in an online role-playing game? Is that really theft? Can the person playing the stealing avatar be held accountable in real-world courts of law (a

question addressed in Charles Stross's 2007 novel *Halting State*, where authorities were initially reluctant to intervene in a bank robbery conducted within a role-playing game)? We don't yet have clear strategies to think through the actions of personas that may be distinct from those in the bodies that type those behaviors.

Cues and competence

Online, as in all media and face to face interaction, we try to manage what other people think of us (Goffman, 1959). This impression management may involve outright deception, total honesty, or, most often, a strategic balance of sharing, withholding, and distorting information. Our ability to construct an online identity, whether authentic, fanciful, or manipulative is limited and enabled by the communicative tools, or affordances, a platform makes available and our skill at strategically managing them. In this section, we'll see how we use these cues to build a personal, individualized, identity and to align ourselves with other social groups.

Personal identity

In many online environments, people seek to individualize themselves as different from the other participants. Different kinds of sites and media provide different cues that can facilitate this. In Farside MUD, a fantasy environment, high-level players could purchase genitalia in order to make their avatars sexually mature (Ito, 1997). In MOOs like those discussed in the last chapter, there may be multiple gender identities from which to choose (Danet, 1998). In graphic role-playing games, identities are often created through costumes, weapons, and levels of skill. In a role-playing game like Runescape, which is particularly popular amongst boys in early adolescence, it takes a considerable investment of time and requires a high level of competence to build an identity by collecting the right clothes and weapons, and constructing an impressive in-game dwelling. In Club Penguin, a popular site for children, kids build identities by purchasing their own igloo which they can decorate with the furniture they choose. They can also choose their clothes and may even adopt a Pet Puffle. Not all digital environments are so creative, but all provide us with options for self-presentation. On mailing lists and web boards, our signature files, choices of name, and even our domain names become important markers of who we are.

The most important identity signal may be one's name. An authentic name may be required for trust. Most email providers, web boards, blogs, and SNSs allow users to select any name. On Last.fm, it is unusual to see a real name. Korea's Cyworld, on the other hand, allows people to pick pseudonyms only after their identity has been verified and "the site's search functions are able to validate the name, date of birth, and gender of other users" (Kim & Yun, 2007). Facebook requires real names. One analysis of 4,540 Facebook profiles of students at Carnegie Mellon University (USA) (Gross & Acquisti, 2005) found that 89 percent of user names seemed to be real. Only 8 percent were clearly false and just 3 percent partial; 80 percent had pictures that made them identifiable. However, Facebook's system for recognizing authenticity is flawed, resulting in multiple profiles bearing the names of celebrities, businesses, or websites. "If this rule is being followed," jokes Baron (2008: 82), "then Karl Marx, Anne Boleyn, and Kermit the Frog are alive and well."

In textual media, the use of written language is a significantly more powerful force in making and forming impressions than it is when people interact body to body. While physically attractive people may be the ones who get noticed at a party, it's often the articulate, insightful and witty ones who know how to spell who gain notice at the online equivalent. Language is also our primary tool for telling others about ourselves through self-disclosure. As we'll discuss in the next chapter, self-disclosure is indispensable in turning strangers into relational partners and to maintaining ongoing relationships. Its strategic management is essential to shaping the impressions others form of us.

The images we associate with ourselves, including our photographs and avatars are also important identity cues. On Facebook, people usually use photographs of themselves as identifiers. On Last.fm, in contrast, avatar pictures rarely depict the users, just as

users rarely use real names. The appeal of those pictures alone may lead to the initiation of new relationships, as Last.fm users told me when I asked them about how they came to friend the people they did (Baym & Ledbetter, 2009).

Websites and blogs provide spaces to use language, but they provide many other potential identity cues. This makes technical competence in cue manipulation particularly important. We need to know how to make the blank slate of a web page into something meaningful. Knowledge of language and spelling matters, but so too does facility with html and CSS. In a content analysis of 1,000 homepages from four different networks, Papacharissi (2002) found that many people tried to display an image of technological competence. Some displayed "what ranged from uncontrolled enthusiasm to blatant exhibitionism," while those "much more proficient in Web design displayed this savvy by avoiding the mass produced templates, animations, and other 'recipes,' and asserting their individuality and creativity with original HTML code" (Papacharissi, 2002: 656).

One of the unique qualities of most SNSs is that they engineer self-presentation by providing predetermined sets of categories through which to build identities. Though the categories vary, most provide slots for demographic information including age, place of residence, and general interests. Lampe, Ellison, and Steinfeld (2007) used automated data collection to gather profile information from all available profiles on their university's Facebook system and found that, on average, users filled in 59 percent of fields available to them. Gross and Acquisti (2005) found that 98.5 percent of their university's Facebook users disclosed their full birthdates. General-interest categorizations encourage users to construct themselves in part by identifying with popular culture. The early SNS, Friendster, offered five categories (general interests, music, movies, television, and books) which are also used on MySpace, Facebook, and Orkut (Liu, 2007). This kind of categorization of the self began in online dating sites (Fiore & Donath, 2005), the assumption being that people who share such tastes are likely to be interpersonally compatible and hence good prospects for relational success. On Last.fm, we found that friends were more likely than not to share musical taste, but the extent to which a Last.fm relationship was motivated by the other person's taste in music and a shared musical history did not predict how developed their relationship was (Baym & Ledbetter, 2009). Taste lists also provide a way to perform our individuality by differentiating ourselves from others (Liu, 2007). Liu (2007) examined 127,477 MySpace profiles and found that "on average, MySpace users tended to differentiate themselves from their friends, rather than identifying with their friends' tastes," perhaps in order to distinguish themselves from the other people in their social circles.

Social identity

Self-presentations online are built of all of these cues as we appropriate them in the service of crafting our identities. Some see online identities as free-floating in this space, and see our use of cues as a potential act of pure self-reinvention. But, far from free-floating, even online, our identities are entwined with the identities of others. Individual identities are deeply enmeshed with social identities. We build self-representations by linking to others. Others also contribute to the online pool of information available about ourselves. We also indicate our membership in social groups that invoke shared conceptions of insider and outsider.

We link to others in many ways. On blogs, homepages, and other sites, people use links that send messages about who they are and with whom they seek to be affiliated. Those links serve as elements of our representation, and the behavior of and impressions left by those others become elements in the mix, shaping how people are perceived. In an analysis of homepages, Wynn and Katz (1998) found that identities constructed through homepages were richly contextualized in offline social groups through self-descriptions, implied audiences, and links to websites of other people and groups. When links to others require the others' acceptance, as is the case in many SNSs, the sheer number of links a person has can be a status marker. People may be evaluated by how many friends they have (boyd, 2006; Fono and Raynes-Goldie, 2006).

One of the unique affordances of SNSs is that they display friend

lists, making everyone's connections visible to at least some others. Donath and boyd (2004: 72) were among the first to note that displaying one's connection carries potential risk to one's reputation, writing that "[s]eeing someone within the context of their connections provides the viewer with information about them. Social status, political beliefs, musical taste, etc., may be inferred from the company one keeps." Whatever one writes within a profile may be supported or undermined by one's visible connections. On SNSs our friends' names, words, and even looks can influence others' impressions of us. Walther et al. (2008) had one group evaluate the attractiveness of people's photos. They then created fake Facebook profiles to display photos of friends with varying degrees of attractiveness and had another set of subjects evaluate the profiles. The same people were rated as more attractive when they had better-looking Facebook friends, and less attractive when they had links to unattractive people.

Friends can also affect one's image by writing on one's "wall" or "shoutbox" (Walther et al., 2008), tagging photographs with one's name, and commenting on content one has uploaded. In some SNSs, people can do this even if they have not been accepted as a friend. "This makes participative social networking technologies different from Web pages, e-mail, or online chat," Walther et al. write (2008: 29), "because all those technologies allow the initiator complete control over what appears in association with his- or herself." Content posted by others may contribute disproportionately to one's image because it may be seen as less biased by a desire to look good.

The self-representations we create are far from the only source of information available about us online, and most people who become interested in learning about an individual will turn to search engines where, if anything comes up at all, it is likely to be a mix of what the person has put online and information placed there by others (and sometimes about others who share the same name). People may post information about us, tag us in photographs, link to us, and discuss us, and all of these uncontrollable bits of information about our identities may come up in searches whether we wish they did or not.

Different media platforms provide differing cues for building shared social and cultural identities. Whether, and how, a user can construct a racial identity will vary considerably from site to site. In her analysis of BlackPlanet.com, Byrne (2007) reports that, until 2005, members' only choices for racial identification were Black, Asian, Latino, Native American, and White. Following Nakamura (2002), she argues this "forces users into dominant notions of race," leaving little room for intercultural diversity or intraracial identities. Other SNSs, such as MySpace, Last.fm, or Facebook, do not provide any category for race, which, one might argue, reflects an effort to render race irrelevant or, following Silver (2000), an assumption that the users, like most of the developers, are White.

Like race, nationality can be a charged identity category and platforms differ in whether and how they foreground it. We saw in chapter 3 that nations vary dramatically in the extent to which they are represented online, and that English-speaking nations are disproportionately present. On-site cultures emerge around national identities. Last.fm used to display all users' nationality if they'd selected it from a drop-down list of options, leading to some distress from people such as Scots, some of whom did not self-identify as residents of the United Kingdom (which was provided in the drop-down menu), but of Scotland (which was not).The most striking example of this is Orkut (Fragoso, 2006). Orkut, owned by Google, launched as a US-based SNS in 2004. People could join only when invited by an existing member. Within a short time, Brazilians outnumbered every other country's members, a phenomenon which usually has been attributed to Brazilians' purported sociable and outgoing nature, an explanation which is surely inadequate (Fragoso, 2006). People on Orkut began to construct their identities in terms of nationalism, leading to intense conflicts that were often grounded in language wars as Portuguese speakers colonized what had been English-language discussion groups.

In international contexts, claiming a national identity can be a way of differentiating one's self. Miller and Slater's (2000) interviews with Trinidadians about their internet use described Trinis as often surprised to realize that the strangers they met from other

countries online had not heard of their country. They responded by seeking to represent Trinidad as part of their own identities online, acting as nationalistic selves. They filled their homepages with links to official Trini sites, and, as we discussed in chapter 3, replicated norms of the Trini speech community in their online interactions.

Even when race, nationality, or other social identities are not explicit, they may be imputed from cues such as the taste selections on one's SNS profile or the interests one displays. Our vocabulary choices may reveal our age or nationality. It's not hard, for instance, to spot the British on Twitter when they use terms such as "bollocks." Tastes and interests are shaped by socioeconomic factors, including money, class, and education, as well as by age and locational cohorts (Bourdieu, 1984; Liu, 2007). Digital identity cues are "signals of social position in an information based society" (Donath, 2007).

According to the Social Identity Theory of Deindividuation Effects, or SIDE Model, the extent to which people identify and behave in accordance with social rather than personal identities is influenced by the medium's affordances, such as anonymity, which interact with social context, and social understandings of the self (e.g. Spears & Lea, 1992). In a series of experiments manipulating the extent to which people in online groups were connected and given varying amounts of information that served to anonymize, individualize, or invoke social identities for participants, Lea, Spears, and their collaborators (e.g. Lea & Spears, 1991) found that, when people have access to individualizing cues, they are more likely to differentiate themselves from one another. In anonymous contexts, however, people are more likely to stereotype and conform to group norms, experiencing more of a sense of "we" and less a sense of "me." This stereotyping extends to our own self-perceptions and behaviors (Postmes & Baym, 2005). Thus, for instance, fans of University of Kansas athletics (the Jayhawks) participating in online forums where their status as a Jayhawk is foregrounded over individualizing social cues are likely to engage in behaviors such as saying nasty things about rivals University of Missouri (the Tigers) and all those affiliated with them. The same individuals, participating in groups that emphasize their individualized identities or shared social identity as Midwestern college students, might be less likely to present themselves as Jayhawks or Tigers and, as a result, get along just fine.

Honesty

I began this chapter with the pervasive idea that people met online may not be trustworthy. As we have seen throughout this book, people often expect others to be less honest online. At one extreme, people are taken to invent entire new disembodied identities. They may also be seen as modestly tweaking themselves around the margins. To the extent online self-representations are grounded in explicit connections with identifiable others, as I have just been discussing, it is difficult to create online selves that wander too far from the embodied ones. On SNSs, where people often identify themselves with real names, new people are usually encountered because they are latent ties (Haythornthwaite, 2002) – people with at least one common on-site friend – and are hence more likely to be trusted. As we will see, though, people may fudge the truth on those sites as well.

One might not be surprised that people are pressured toward honesty in SNSs, yet still expect that, in other more anonymous online environments, people would be less honest. In general, the idea that anonymity makes people lie has not been well supported by the research. Rutter and Smith (1999) studied over 17,000 messages in an online newsgroup, and found that fantasy selves were rare. In r.a.t.s, group norms encouraged honest self-presentation (Baym, 2000). Though people may have tinkered with their self-presentations around the edges, only one person, who insisted he was the nephew of the fictional soap opera character Aunt Phoebe, was discernibly deceptive during my three years in the site. New users with anonymous usernames were regularly asked to share their real names and a little about themselves so we could get to know them better. In-depth interviews with a small sample of users of chat rooms (Henderson & Gilding, 2004) showed that the interviewees focused on the continuities rather than the differences

between online and offline relationships, and described high rates of honest self-disclosure in both.

Whether anonymous or identifiable, people seem at least as likely to be more honest online than off. Reduced social cues make it easier to lie, but separation, time lags, and sparse cues also remove social pressures that make lying seem a good idea. When we can't be seen and can easily log off and change screen names, we don't have to face the consequences of disclosures gone wrong. When the people with whom we're interacting online don't know any of the same people that we do offline, word won't get around (McKenna et al., 2002). The sense of safety in anonymous sites may be important for honest self-expression. This can also be important for those who are socially anxious and lonely or who have stigmatized identities. McKenna and her collaborators (2002) emailed a survey to every fifth poster in a sample of 20 Usenet newsgroups. They found that people who were socially anxious or lonely were more likely to feel they could express their real selves online, and this was positively correlated with developing relationships online that led to other media and offline meetings. Even when interacting with those who know us, the ability to write out one's thoughts and not have to face the other immediately can lead to more honesty. Americans report being more honest with loved ones through email than face to face (Rainie, Lenhart, Fox, Spooner, & Horrigan, 2000).

Testing out honest self-disclosure and expressing one's "real" self online can be empowering and liberating. Practicing skills such as assertiveness can help people to work through issues involving control and mastery, gain competence, and find a comfort which they can then transfer to their embodied encounters. This is especially so when they receive positive feedback for their online expressions of identity (McKenna & Bargh, 1998; Myers, 1987b; Turkle, 1996, 1997). Gay teenagers, for instance, may first come out in online communities focused on gay identity. Finding an accepting cohort helps them to feel at ease with acknowledging their homosexuality, giving them the confidence to tell their family and peers offline (McKenna & Bargh, 1998; see also Gray, 2009). The socially anxious people McKenna et al. (2002) studied formed

new close relationships through the internet and reported less loneliness and greater ease making friends offline two years later. The power people may feel when given the mediated affordance of greater cue control extends beyond computer mediation. In a prescient article, Sarch (1993) interviewed women about their use of the telephone in dating relationships and found that having control over the cues they conveyed to their male partners gave them a greater sense of power in the developing relationship.

It would be naïve to imagine that people do not deceive online. With the rare and well-publicized exception, however, most lies told through the wonders of technology's affordances are minor strategic manipulations rather than malevolent falsehoods. Whitty and Gavin (2001) trained their students to conduct interviews with people who regularly used the internet in their study of online relational development. These 60 interviews showed that people were worried about honesty, and with good reason. Men and women offered different reasons for deception. Women who lied generally did so for safety reasons. The men rarely reported that rationale; they were, however, more likely to report that the internet's anonymity made them feel more able to disclose honestly. Whitty and Gavin conclude that "the ideals that are important in traditional relationships, such as trust, honesty, and commitment, are equally important online" (2001: 630). On SNS profiles and websites people may claim to like things they don't, or omit embarrassing true favorites, in order to create a public image in line with what they think others find attractive (Liu, Maes, & Davenport, 2006). On Last.fm, people routinely turn off the site's recording and display of their current listening when they are streaming artists inconsistent with the image they wish to project. They may also play cool artists on repeat when they are away in order to appear to like what they do not. Ellison, Heino, and Gibbs (2006) interviewed people who used a large online dating site. They found that people were generally truthful, but many exaggerated socially appealing qualities, claiming to weigh less than they really did, to be taller than they really were, or to be nonsmokers. They may have posted photos from when they were younger (Ellison et al., 2006). People building profiles in dating sites understood that they had to be credible and

sought to manage the tension between that and the need to make themselves appear attractive enough to raise interest.

Sometimes being deceptive is more about presenting one's ideal self than a fictitious one. As one blogger (2birds1blog, 2008) wrote about choosing her SNS profile image:

> As a girl, I choose my facebook photo primarily by how unrealistically attractive I look in it. It's narcissistic, but you can't deny that you do the same thing. I'm not going to lie, sometimes when I'm getting ready to go out, I'll evaluate whether or not I'm lookin' "Facebook-worthy" that night. In other instances I'll even attend certain events just because I think I'll get a cute Facebook pic out of it. Overall, it's accepted that girls use their Facebook pic as an outlet to display their "Oh my Gawd I look HAWT!" pictures.

When people lied in dating sites, saying they were thin or a non-smoker, they sometimes genuinely believed that by the time they met the person they sought they would have lost weight or quit smoking (Ellison et al., 2006). What's more, people are sometimes limited in their self-knowledge and what they believe to be true about themselves may not be seen in them by others, a phenomenon Ellison et al. (2006) referred to as the "foggy mirror." Complicating the picture further, people may also lie because they have heard so much discourse about the dangers of meeting people online that they feel compelled to protect themselves by lying about who they are; hence, Whitty and Gavin's (2001) finding that women may lie about where they live, or my son's use of fake identities in his online activity. Teens and children are often taught by parents and other significant adults never to reveal their names, phone numbers, addresses, or any other identifying information online, essentially instructing them to lie.

Just as reduced cues and distance may encourage some to be more honest online by removing the social risk associated with telling the truth, technological design and affordances also influence deception. Ellison et al. (2006) found that one reason people lied about their ages in dating site profiles was to avoid being screened out in searches that clustered search results into systemically predetermined age ranges. Hancock, Thom-Santelli, and Ritchie (2004) had students keep a communication diary in which they recorded all of their efforts to mislead someone for seven days.

They found that, on average, people told 6.11 lies a day. Deception rates were highest on the telephone, followed by face to face communication. Email had the most honesty. They suggest this is because people realize they are less likely to get caught when using synchronous media that are neither stored nor replicable.

Authenticity and relationship

Regardless of how we present ourselves in digital environments, in most encounters others will have fairly limited cues with which to interpret us, and may or may not make of them the meanings we had intended. Social psychologists have described people as "cognitive misers" who try to get as much information as possible out of as few cues as we can. In mediated environments, where there are so many blanks to fill in, people make more out of others' small cues than we might face to face (Ellison et al., 2006). An ambiguous subject line, a single photograph, a short self-description, or a shared interest leads us to infer other information based on our stereotypes and assumptions about how social reality works. On Twitter, for example, someone took my frequent banter with one music business strategist to mean that I shared all of that person's positions. I don't.

We also "give off" as many cues as we "give" (Goffman, 1959), inadvertently revealing information about ourselves through the ways we behave rather than the content of our messages. Cues given off become highly informative in sparse cue situations (Ellison et al., 2006), so that, for example, poor spelling, which would never become relevant in most early face to face encounters, comes to be a highly significant marker of identity in textual media, taken to reveal sloppiness, lack of education, or other negative qualities. The dating site OkCupid (2009) conducted a lexical analysis of 500,000 first letters men wrote to women through the site in order to identify linguistic strategies that were more and less likely to lead to responses. They found that netspeak (e.g. "ur," "luv") was a turn-off, as were conventional openings such as "hi," "hey," and "hello." Letters beginning with "yo," "what's up," and "how's it going" were far more likely to get replies. Male self-effacement

through terms such as "sorry," "apologize," and "awkward" generated more replies. As I wrote this paragraph I was "followed" by a new person on Twitter. His self-description said he could get me 16,000 Twitter followers in 90 days through an automated process. He had 4 followers. Even if I were out to collect as many followers as possible, I'd have had to go with the information given off over that given. We always form impressions that go beyond what others intended to present with the self-identifying cues provided. The point is that, in reduced cue environments, very small pieces of information, which were often not intended to be sources of information about the self, can become inordinately influential. This makes it considerably harder to present an inauthentic self.

Looking at the evidence, there's no compelling reason to assume that people who meet online are inherently less able or willing to represent themselves as they understand themselves to be than they are when they meet in unmediated contexts. People may lie online, but, then, face to face communication has never been a guarantor of truth, as people whose married lovers have sworn they were single or intended to leave their spouses will quickly tell you. The flip side of our fear of online deception is our gullibility in believing that vision prevents us from falling for lies.

As SIP argued, when people interact online with others over time, they become more likely to solicit and present "socially revealing, relational behavior" (Walther et al., 1994: 465), leading new acquaintances who pursue relationships to fairly accurate understandings of one another's identities. Over time, impressions formed through online interaction become increasingly similar to those formed face to face (Walther & Burgoon, 1992). When people meet online, they may need to make a leap of faith in deciding they know each other well enough to trust them (Henderson & Gilding, 2004). However, believing that you know and can trust someone else always requires a leap of faith, no matter how you meet.

Summary

When people meet online, it raises questions about whether they are honest about who they are, and, hence, whether they and the relationships they create can be trusted. At the core of the matter is the fact that contexts that transcend space and offer few social cues provide people with considerably more latitude and control in shaping the ways they present themselves to others. Different sites and technologies, with their differing affordances, influence self-presentation in different ways, whether that is by providing visible links to other people, privileging competence in web design over template use, or offering virtual attire and accoutrements to build identities.

However, as we've seen, the fact that the technological affordances of media do influence self-presentations does not mean that they determine them. Indeed, the same affordances can have opposite effects for different people in different circumstances. Some may feel free to lie, while others may feel free to be more honest than they would in person. Most people, in most cases, seem to err on the side of truthfulness, especially when they are linked to other people and social identities through their self-representations, although they may manipulate their self-presentations strategically and, at times, not entirely honestly. At this point, despite horror stories about online deception, there's no compelling reason to think that the people one meets online are inherently less trustworthy than those we meet in embodied contexts. The identity foundations on which new relationships are built can be every bit as sturdy online as off.